



IMAGINE A SITUATION where your travel booking platform is an interactive part of your holiday plans. Based on your choices, moods and aspirations, the platform could integrate and recommend destinations. Not just that, it could even give you an immersive peek into that destination—be it marvelling at the Northern Lights or the Great Barrier Reef; you could actually ‘be’ there with your travel partners in the metaverse—while sitting in your living room.

Travel and technology are all about going beyond and seeing the yet unseen. The expanse of self-service technologies has limitless potential. Indeed, technologies such as virtual reality (VR), augmented reality (AR), Artificial Intelligence (AI), and the Internet of Things (IoT) have already started reshaping how we look at travel. Future developments in the coming years will only accentuate this trend further. From no-contact flight boarding, our mobile phones could ensure the correct temperature of rooms and amenities customised according to preferences and health conditions at the time of hotel check-ins.

Technology has had a seminal impact on travel, and its effect will be more visible over the next 20 years, providing people with convenience, safety, and fewer touchpoints. However, we must

The Future of Tourism is Tech

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BY DEEP KALRA

remember that travelling is, after all, a transaction in experience. We travel for enjoyment, to discover fresh delights and mysteries, to engage with nature, and experience new joys. While technology is rapidly assisting in making that experience more complete and immersive, it will never be able to replace the actual experience of physical travel.

India, ‘the’ destination: Few countries can offer a traveller the

highest mountain peaks alongside the vast blue oceans, the densest of forests, or the sandy expanses of a desert. The ancient rock-cut caves of Ajanta-Ellora, the feeling of the raw power of the cascading waterfalls of Jabalpur, the misty Jaintia Hills, the serene and mysterious Andaman Islands or the daunting Himalayas—the moments experienced here are of pure bliss that transcends the boundaries of time and technology. India offers a kaleidoscope of stunning landscapes and enriching cultures that have captivated travellers for centuries. As we mark 100 years of Independence, India needs to fall in love once again with its natural wonders. The vision to establish India as a global tourism hub must be propelled by developing and showcasing the unique and memorable experiences that this nation can offer.

However, despite this natural bounty, India is currently the 22nd most visited nation in the world. To be amongst the Top 10 by 2047, we must focus on showcasing the country’s distinct cultural heritage, preserving its majestic natural beauty, and investing in infrastructure and hospitality services to create an un-